the well’.

So it was for many that their lives were quenched before their thirst; and few showed any pity for another’s condition.

Certainly not Tardi Beg, that paragon of self-interest. This chieftain had commandeered a well for himself and was using it to pull out water for his own animals, denying access even to Humayun’s horses and camels. Humayun’s attendants came to complain, swearing that they would ‘either have water or be killed’. Humayun had to intervene and more or less beg water from Tardi Beg, speaking to him in their native Turki: ‘Be so good as to draw off your people for a short time . . .’[45]

Tardi Beg complied and bloodshed was prevented, but still, whatever the curmudgeonly chief allowed the animals, it wasn’t enough. Another march of a day and a night brought the company to a tank. Horses and camels, no longer dependent on the benevolence of their masters, saw the delicious wetness before them and waded in. Many drank so much they died.

The pity of it was beyond description, and Jouher does not test his pen, writing only, and bluntly: ‘the misery we suffered at this stage was intolerable’.

It was also, however, near its end. On 22 August 1542, Humayun’s company – only eight of whom still had horses left to ride[46] – reached the rounded turrets and thick walls of the fortress of Umarkot, and found shelter with its ruler, Rana Prasad.

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Now that he had refuge, there were two matters that required Humayun’s most urgent attention. One was clean clothes. Jouher offers the quite wonderful scene of his master lounging in his dressing gown, having sent his clothes – sweat-stiff and pungent, no doubt – to the wash. Second was money. Humayun didn’t have any, neither to pay his men nor to offer the rana; and his chieftains, as Abul Fazl puts it, dismayed, ‘grudged’ him their wealth ‘even when his Majesty asked for it!’

Once again, however, Humayun reveals himself to be a far more canny operator than his reputation suggests. He assembled all the chiefs in his tent, as if for a meeting, then sent some trusted men to ransack their baggage. This produced a small loot of money, jewels and clothes, of which